actors involved; and the new forms of 'South–South indebtedness' that resulted from these transactions and their potential consequences.

The relationships between Brazil and Africa have been studied under different perspectives in areas such as history, culture, ethnicity and language. Our approach will focus on political-economic relations (commercial, finance and business) since 2003. Under Lula da Silva's government, Portuguese-speaking African countries gained unprecedented relevance as a result of interest by multinational corporations with headquarters in Brazil, especially construction, oil and gas, and mining companies.[2] This expansion enjoyed strong political support resulting in the concomitant increase of direct export credit policies and the financing of Brazilian business projects in Africa. Seen not from an isolated but from a mutually related perspective, 'cooperation for development' has direct consequences for new political–business relations. There has emerged a complex field of dispute between political and business interests. In our viewpoint, such recent advances made by Brazil towards Africa can be represented by the trinity of 'investment-cooperation-financing'. Each has distinct characteristics and dynamics, but all of them are articulated by the same political and economic project. This is the core of the contemporary relations between Brazil and Africa, particularly in the Portuguese-speaking countries.

In general, we can point out two main approaches to rebuild and value Brazil's role in Africa. The first one we call 'hegemonic vision',[3] which focuses on the image of Brazil as a 'partner' that establishes horizontal relations with its African counterparts. Celso Amorim's (2011) statement is quite a good example of Brazil's projected image as a model to be followed by African countries. It says that 'for each African problem there [would be] a Brazilian solution'. This viewpoint is also shared by some multilateral financial organisations, such as the World Bank which, together with the Institute of Applied Economic Research (IPEA), claims that 'the new Africa coincides with global Brazil' (IPEA and World Bank 2011:3).

On the other hand, there are some more critical voices of the performance of the 'emerging countries' (mainly China and also Brazil) under a neo-colonialist viewpoint which sees the African continent as a new field of dispute between the traditional and the new, emerging powers over African natural resources and markets.[4] In spite of good intentions, both visions tend to victimise African countries and their governments and underestimate their capacity for action. They usually rebuild the Brazilian presence in Africa from a Brazilian perspective and, though coming to interesting and important conclusions, they end up oversimplifying the established relations in these interactions.

We think that both viewpoints have a common element: the use of 'lenses'